

client relationship was too complex to simply blame the broker.

The third stage of recrimination was blaming myself. Here I concluded that I was doomed to failure, a Midas in reverse, and that everything I touched would soon be bankrupt. This, I'm told, is a common and primitive attitude. I've observed it in many friends who say, "I'm death on equities," "Put me in a stock and the company's a goner," or "With me, every investment is a total loss."

In this deprecatory spirit, I went back over everything—people I'd wronged, deadlines I'd missed, sins I'd committed—as if somewhere I'd find the cause of an obvious jinx. Was I my own worst enemy on Wall Street? I wondered about a fatal flaw, or an angry god, that made my poor performance a foregone conclusion. Why was I still being punished?

It sounds silly, I know, but average investors are left with no rational explanations for their uncanny histories of debits. I met a man who told me he'd bought a computer stock at \$4 and watched it go to \$50, then was unable to sell at \$40, \$30, \$20, and continued to hold until it dropped to \$2. He suspected he'd been mesmerized, and wondered if it had anything to do with not telling his bank of an error in his favor. A woman I knew who bought Schlumberger at \$80, only to see it plunge to \$30, thought it might have to do with her driving a gas-guzzling car during the last energy crisis.

Once you're in the doomed-to-failure phase, it can last for months. Luckily, it didn't last that long for me. Srully Blotnick coaxed me out of it.

Srully Blotnick! There's a name you couldn't forget. It caught my attention in the card catalog of the local library, to which I'd returned in search of a new approach. His book was called *Winning: the Psychology of Successful Investment*, published back in 1979. It was based on Mr. Blotnick's 10-year study of 1,103 average investors from 1966 to 1976. He followed them through one bull market and one bear market to see what happened to their money and why. (Recent criticism of Mr. Blotnick's methodology in no way diminished my enthusiasm for his findings.)

Of these 1,103 people, only 53 made any sizable profit, and only four did "exceptionally well." Many ended up with less than what they started, which to me was no shock. The why of it is where